

# CertiGuard AI

AI-Powered Certificate Fraud Detection & Verification

## BUSINESS STRATEGY & INVESTMENT REPORT

Market: India · Source: Day 23 Customer & MVP Blueprint · July 2026

**VERDICT: ■ VALIDATE**

*Prepared as an AI Co-Founder / YC-style advisory analysis.  
Directional strategic guidance — not audited financial or legal advice.*

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## 1. Executive Summary

CertiGuard AI proposes an OCR + computer-vision + ML engine that forensically detects forged, edited, or fabricated academic and professional certificates — including legacy paper and scanned documents that government infrastructure like DigiLocker/NAD does not cover. The underlying diligence memo scored this Founder-Market Fit 7.2/10 and Overall Validation 6.4/10, landing on a **Conditional Go**. A working prototype exists, the problem is well-documented and costly, and a genuine competitive white-space is visible. But the venture is pre-revenue and pre-pilot: there are zero paying customers, zero signed LOIs, and no structured willingness-to-pay survey. This report applies revenue-first, distribution-first, evidence-first discipline to determine whether CertiGuard AI can become a sustainable business — and lays out the concrete 30-60 day path to find out.

**Bottom line:** this is not yet an investable business — it is a validated problem in search of a validated business model. The single highest-leverage action is converting 2-3 pilot institutions into paying, referenceable customers within the next quarter.

## 2. Blueprint Summary & Assumptions Extracted

### Startup Summary (Source of Truth: Day 23 Blueprint)

- AI SaaS/API forensically verifies academic & professional certificates — including legacy paper/scanned documents — via OCR + computer vision + ML, returning a fraud-risk score in minutes.
- Targets India: mid/large private universities, autonomous colleges, and recruitment/staffing agencies (Phase 1); government bodies and large enterprises (Phase 2).
- Buyer persona is Priya Menon — a Registrar or HR/TA compliance lead, 32-48, risk-averse, needs Dean/CHRO sign-off, trusts pilot proof over marketing.
- Key competitors are manual BPO verifiers (AuthBridge/IDfy), DigiLocker/NAD (digital-only, forward-looking), blockchain credentialing, and the status quo of in-house manual checks.
- A working prototype exists (strong signal); informal peer/faculty feedback is positive but weak evidence; there is no paying pilot, LOI, or formal demand survey yet.
- MVP scope: OCR extraction + tampering-detection engine + fraud-risk score + upload portal + DPDP-aligned privacy policy + pilot onboarding flow. Explicitly deferred: ATS/HRMS integration, blockchain, SSO, mobile app.
- Pricing is a hypothesis, not validated: per-check for smaller orgs, per-seat/annual for large universities, and a freemium pilot offer to remove adoption friction.
- Final blueprint verdict: Customer Clarity 60/100, Problem Severity 80/100, PMF Potential 55/100, MVP Readiness 50/100 — 'Promising but Unvalidated.'

### Assumptions Extracted (to be tested, not treated as fact)

| Category | Assumption                                                                            | Risk if Wrong                                               |
|----------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| Customer | Registrars/HR leads will personally champion a new vendor through Dean/CHRO approval. | Long sales cycle stalls indefinitely; no champion, no deal. |

| Category   | Assumption                                                                                                   | Risk if Wrong                                                                                  |
|------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| MVP        | OCR + CV tampering detection will hit useful accuracy on real, messy Indian certificate formats.             | If accuracy is mediocre on real docs, trust and adoption collapse.                             |
| Value Prop | Speed (minutes vs weeks) and forensic tampering-detection are enough to switch buyers off manual/BPO checks. | Buyers may tolerate slow manual checks if switching cost/risk feels higher.                    |
| Pricing    | Per-check and per-seat pricing will be acceptable to budget-constrained colleges/agencies.                   | Price sensitivity or procurement friction could kill conversion even after a successful pilot. |
| Revenue    | Pilot organizations will convert to paid contracts after a free/discounted trial.                            | Freemium pilots could become permanent free usage with no conversion trigger.                  |
| GTM        | Agencies will move faster than universities, providing early revenue and case studies.                       | If agencies also stall, there is no fast lane to first revenue.                                |

### 3. Business Reality Check

#### Who pays?

Institutions and agencies pay — not students or job candidates. The budget holder is a Registrar/Admissions Head (education) or HR Head/Talent Acquisition Lead (agencies/corporates). This is a B2B compliance purchase, not a consumer one, which means longer cycles but higher deal value and stickier retention once integrated into a workflow.

#### Why do they pay?

They pay to reduce a specific, costly risk: fraud discovered after enrollment or hiring is far more expensive than catching it upfront (legal, reputational, refund/severance costs), and accreditation bodies increasingly expect a documented verification process rather than informal checks. The pitch is risk reduction and audit-trail creation, not just convenience.

#### How will they discover the product?

Primarily founder-led outreach and warm referral in Phase 1 — direct pilot proposals to shortlisted institutions/agencies, LinkedIn content aimed at registrars and HR leads (an extension of the founder's existing ABTalks content practice), and case studies from completed pilots. There is no paid-acquisition or inbound engine yet, and none should be built before pilot proof exists.

#### Biggest growth risks?

(1) Institutional sales cycles are long and committee-driven, which is a poor fit for a founder who is a full-time student with limited weekly bandwidth. (2) The addressable legacy-document market could shrink over time as DigiLocker/NAD digital issuance expands. (3) With zero case studies today, every new prospect conversation starts from zero trust.

#### Biggest monetization risks?

(1) Pricing is entirely untested — there is no willingness-to-pay data, only a hypothesis. (2) A freemium pilot could become a permanent expectation with no natural trigger to convert to paid. (3) A single high-profile false positive or false negative in a compliance-sensitive category could damage trust faster than any amount of marketing can rebuild it.

#### Weakest assumptions to validate first?

In priority order: (a) will at least one pilot organization actually sign an LOI or pay after a successful trial — not just say positive things informally; (b) does the detection engine hit a defensible accuracy rate on real, non-curated Indian certificate formats; (c) will agencies really move faster than universities, since the entire near-term revenue plan depends on that speed differential.

## 4. Business Strategy Report

The following sections translate the blueprint into an operating strategy, evaluated against revenue, distribution, evidence, and execution discipline rather than feature scope or market-size theory.

### 4.1 Business Model Canvas

| Block                  | Detail                                                                                                                                                                               |
|------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Customer Segments      | Mid/large private universities & autonomous colleges (500-20,000 students); recruitment/staffing agencies (5,000+ verifications/yr); later, government bodies and large enterprises. |
| Value Proposition      | Minutes-not-weeks fraud-risk scoring on legacy paper/scanned certificates, at a price point below enterprise BGV vendors, purpose-built for the Indian document landscape.           |
| Channels               | Founder-led direct outreach, pilot proposals, LinkedIn/content marketing to registrars and HR leads, referral from completed pilots.                                                 |
| Customer Relationships | White-glove pilot onboarding, human-in-the-loop review for flagged documents, ongoing accuracy reporting/dashboards to sustain trust.                                                |
| Revenue Streams        | Per-check pricing (smaller orgs), per-seat/annual subscription (larger universities), freemium pilot offer as an adoption driver, future API/integration tier.                       |
| Key Resources          | OCR/CV/ML detection engine, benchmark test set of genuine + forged certificates, founder's technical credibility and network.                                                        |
| Key Activities         | Model accuracy improvement, pilot execution and measurement, DPDP-aligned data handling, case-study/benchmark publication.                                                           |
| Key Partners           | Advisor/mentor with HR-tech or compliance experience; potential future partnership (not competition) with DigiLocker/NAD; academic institutions as design partners.                  |
| Cost Structure         | Founder time (opportunity cost as a student), compute/OCR processing costs, potential human-in-the-loop review labor, eventual compliance/security certification costs.              |

### 4.2 Revenue & Pricing Strategy

Anchor below enterprise background-check vendors and position CertiGuard AI as an add-on forensic layer, not a full background-verification replacement.

| Tier           | Who it's for                           | Purpose                                                           |
|----------------|----------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Freemium Pilot | First 2-3 target institutions/agencies | Remove adoption friction, generate benchmark and case-study data. |
| Per-Check      | Smaller colleges, recruitment agencies | Low-commitment entry price; fastest path to first paying revenue. |

| Tier                      | Who it's for                             | Purpose                                                    |
|---------------------------|------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| Per-Seat / Annual         | Larger universities, enterprise HR teams | Higher-value, stickier contracts once volume justifies it. |
| API / Integration (later) | HRMS/ATS-integrated customers            | Deferred until pilot demand and core accuracy are proven.  |

**Discipline note:** treat every price point above as a hypothesis until at least one organization has actually paid or signed an LOI. Pricing conversations should be part of every pilot debrief, not decided in isolation.

### 4.3 Go-To-Market Strategy

- Phase 0 (Weeks 1-4): Founder-led discovery interviews and 2-3 free pilots — no selling, only learning and proving accuracy.
- Phase 1 (Months 2-3): Convert pilot organizations to first paying per-check contracts; publish one case study.
- Phase 2 (Months 4-6): Expand within converted accounts (more departments/branches) and use referrals to reach 5-10 paying customers.
- Phase 3 (Month 6+): Only after repeatable paid conversion, consider API/HRMS integration and a broader agency-first expansion.

### 4.4 Customer Acquisition Strategy

- Prioritize recruitment/staffing agencies over large universities first — smaller buying committees, faster decisions.
- Use direct, personalized outreach (not mass email) — a 1-page pilot proposal tailored to each shortlisted organization.
- Layer in LinkedIn content aimed specifically at registrars and HR/TA leads, building on the founder's existing ABTalks content habit and audience-building experience.
- Time outreach to buying triggers: a recent fraud incident, an upcoming NAAC/NBA accreditation cycle, or visibly outgrown manual-verification capacity.
- Treat every completed pilot as an acquisition asset: a one-page case study with accuracy and turnaround numbers becomes the next prospect's proof.

### 4.5 First 100 Users Plan

| Range  | Approach                                                                                                        |
|--------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 0-20   | Founder-led direct outreach to recruitment agencies — fastest deal cycle, lowest institutional friction.        |
| 20-50  | Convert 2-3 pilot colleges into paying per-check customers using pilot accuracy data as proof.                  |
| 50-80  | Referrals from satisfied pilot organizations, plus outreach timed to NAAC/NBA accreditation cycles.             |
| 80-100 | Content-led inbound via LinkedIn (ABTalks-style posts for registrars/HR) and an advisor's professional network. |

## 4.6 Competitive Position & Moat

- White-space: forensic tampering-detection on legacy paper/scanned documents, which DigiLocker/NAD does not serve (they cover only newly-issued digital records).
- Price position: below enterprise BGV vendors (AuthBridge/IDfy), aimed at colleges and agencies currently priced out of enterprise-grade verification.
- Speed advantage: an automated minutes-scale turnaround versus days-to-weeks for manual/BPO phone verification.
- **Moat gap to acknowledge:** no proprietary data advantage yet, no published accuracy benchmark, and low switching cost for a first-time buyer to try a competitor. The moat today is founder speed and focus, not defensibility — it must be built through accumulated verified-document data and published trust signals.

## 4.7 Reverse SWOT Analysis

(Reverse SWOT: starting from what could kill the business, then working back to what protects against it.)

| What Could Kill This                                      | What Protects Against It                                                                                                  |
|-----------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| No pilot ever converts to a paying customer               | Ship the freemium pilot with a hard-coded conversion ask built into the pilot agreement, not left informal.               |
| A high-profile false negative/positive in production      | Keep human-in-the-loop review mandatory; never ship fully-automated rejection decisions.                                  |
| Founder burns out balancing full-time study + sales       | Bring on an advisor/co-founder for GTM; scope pilots narrowly; use academic breaks strategically.                         |
| DigiLocker/NAD expands and absorbs the addressable market | Position explicitly as the legacy/non-digitized document layer and explore partnership rather than competition.           |
| Institutional buyers stall in committee indefinitely      | Prioritize agencies first for faster cycles; use buying triggers (fraud incident, accreditation cycle) to create urgency. |

## 4.8 Investor One-Liner & 30-Second Founder Pitch

*"CertiGuard AI catches forged degrees and experience letters that DigiLocker can't see and manual background checks catch too late — turning a weeks-long verification into a minutes-long, India-priced forensic check for colleges and staffing agencies."*

**30-Second Founder Pitch:** "Certificate fraud in India is a real, expensive problem — fake marksheets and forged experience letters slip past manual checks and phone verification every admissions and hiring season. CertiGuard AI uses OCR and computer vision to forensically detect tampering in minutes, including on old paper and scanned documents that government digital systems like DigiLocker were never built to cover. We're not replacing background-check vendors — we're the forensic layer they're missing, priced for colleges and agencies who can't afford enterprise BGV tools. We have a working prototype; the next 60 days are about proving 2-3 institutions will actually pay for it."



## 5. Investment Scorecard

|                      |                        |        |
|----------------------|------------------------|--------|
| Business Viability   | <div><div></div></div> | 58/100 |
| Revenue Potential    | <div><div></div></div> | 50/100 |
| GTM Strength         | <div><div></div></div> | 55/100 |
| Competitive Strength | <div><div></div></div> | 62/100 |
| Investor Readiness   | <div><div></div></div> | 38/100 |

## Business Viability — 58/100

Real, well-documented problem and a working prototype, but the business model is unproven — every revenue assumption is still a hypothesis and depends on long institutional sales cycles.

## Revenue Potential — 50/100

Multiple plausible pricing tiers exist, but zero willingness-to-pay evidence, and the freemium tier risks becoming permanent free usage without a hard conversion mechanism.

## GTM Strength — 55/100

A sensible agencies-first, pilot-driven GTM sequence exists on paper, but it has never been executed, and the founder's bandwidth (full-time student) is a real constraint on execution speed.

## Competitive Strength — 62/100

A genuine, defensible white-space (legacy document forensics) versus DigiLocker/NAD and enterprise BGV vendors — the strongest part of the story — but no data moat or published benchmark yet to lock it in.

## Investor Readiness — 38/100

No paying customers, no LOI, no formal demand survey, and a single-founder, student-bandwidth team. This is pre-seed, evidence-gathering stage, not yet a fundable pitch.

## 6. Visual Dashboard

An interactive HTML/SVG dashboard (CertiGuard\_AI\_Dashboard.html) accompanies this report and mirrors the summary below: business model snapshot, revenue-stream confidence, GTM flow, first-100-users plan, competitive moat, key risks, and the investment scorecard, closing with the overall verdict banner. The static summary version is reproduced here for print/PDF reference.

### VERDICT: ■ VALIDATE

| Panel            | Summary                                                                                                                                                     |
|------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Business Model   | B2B compliance sale to registrars/HR leads; value = fast fraud-risk scoring; channel = direct pilot outreach; cost = founder time + compute + review labor. |
| Revenue Streams  | Per-check (highest near-term confidence) > per-seat/annual > freemium pilot (adoption driver only) > future API tier.                                       |
| GTM Flow         | Discovery interviews -> pilot proposals -> run pilots -> publish case study -> convert to paid + referral.                                                  |
| First 100 Users  | Agencies first (0-20) -> converted pilot colleges (20-50) -> referrals/accreditation-cycle timing (50-80) -> content-led inbound (80-100).                  |
| Competitive Moat | Legacy-document forensic white-space vs. DigiLocker/NAD and enterprise BGV; moat is currently founder-speed, not data or defensibility.                     |
| Key Risks        | Long sales cycles vs. student bandwidth; zero paying pilots today; accuracy/trust risk; DPDP compliance; DigiLocker/NAD market erosion over time.           |

## 7. Founder Action Sheet — Top 10 Actions

| #  | Action                                                                                                    |
|----|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1  | Draft and send a 1-page pilot proposal to 10 target institutions/agencies this week.                      |
| 2  | Conduct 15-20 discovery interviews with registrars, HR/TA leads, and recruitment agencies.                |
| 3  | Build a benchmark test set of known-genuine and known-forged certificates to stress-test accuracy.        |
| 4  | Identify and onboard an advisor/mentor with HR-tech, admissions, or compliance experience.                |
| 5  | Shortlist 5-10 pilot organizations, prioritizing agencies over large universities for faster cycles.      |
| 6  | Run 2-3 real/anonymized document pilots; measure accuracy, false-positive rate, and turnaround time.      |
| 7  | Draft a data-retention and privacy policy aligned to India's DPDP Act before handling any real documents. |
| 8  | Publish accuracy benchmarks publicly and hard-wire a human-in-the-loop review step into the MVP.          |
| 9  | Compile pilot results into a one-page case study; use it to refine per-check/per-seat pricing.            |
| 10 | Decide Go / Pivot / No-Go at day 60; if Go, build a lightweight landing page and a 90-day outreach list.  |

## 8. Sustainability Verdict

CertiGuard AI is solving a real, expensive, well-documented problem and occupies a genuine competitive white-space, but it is not yet a sustainable business — it is an unvalidated business model wrapped around a validated problem. Sustainability hinges entirely on the next 30-60 days: if 2-3 pilot organizations convert to paying, referenceable customers with defensible accuracy numbers, this moves from Validate to a genuine Go decision; if pilots stall or accuracy disappoints on real documents, the honest next step is a pivot toward an agencies-first or API-first / B2B2G model rather than continued feature-building.